for Immy

Stories My Mother Read Me

Fern and the High Grapes

A new retelling of The Fox and the Grapes by Martin Schoffstall. Illustrations by Martin Schoffstall.

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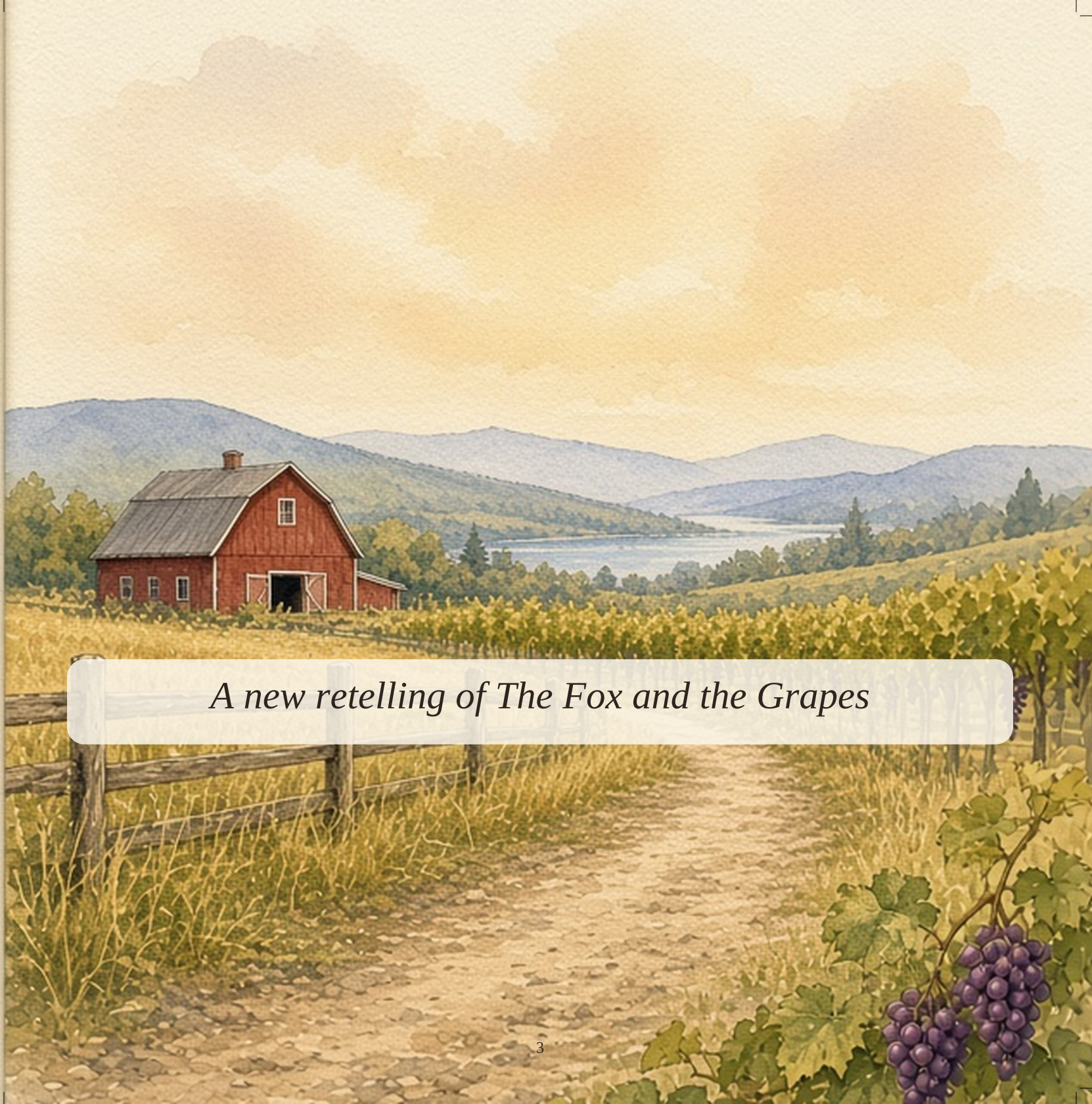

A new retelling of The Fox and the Grapes

Along a farm lane, Fern the fox sniffed the warm summer air.

Sweet grapes hung from a vine overhead. Fern’s tummy rumbled.

A robin perched beside a bunch. Fern wished she could reach it, too.

She crouched low, swished her tail, and sprang. Almost!

She tried from the left. She tried from the right.

Up went her paws. Down came her paws. The grapes stayed high.

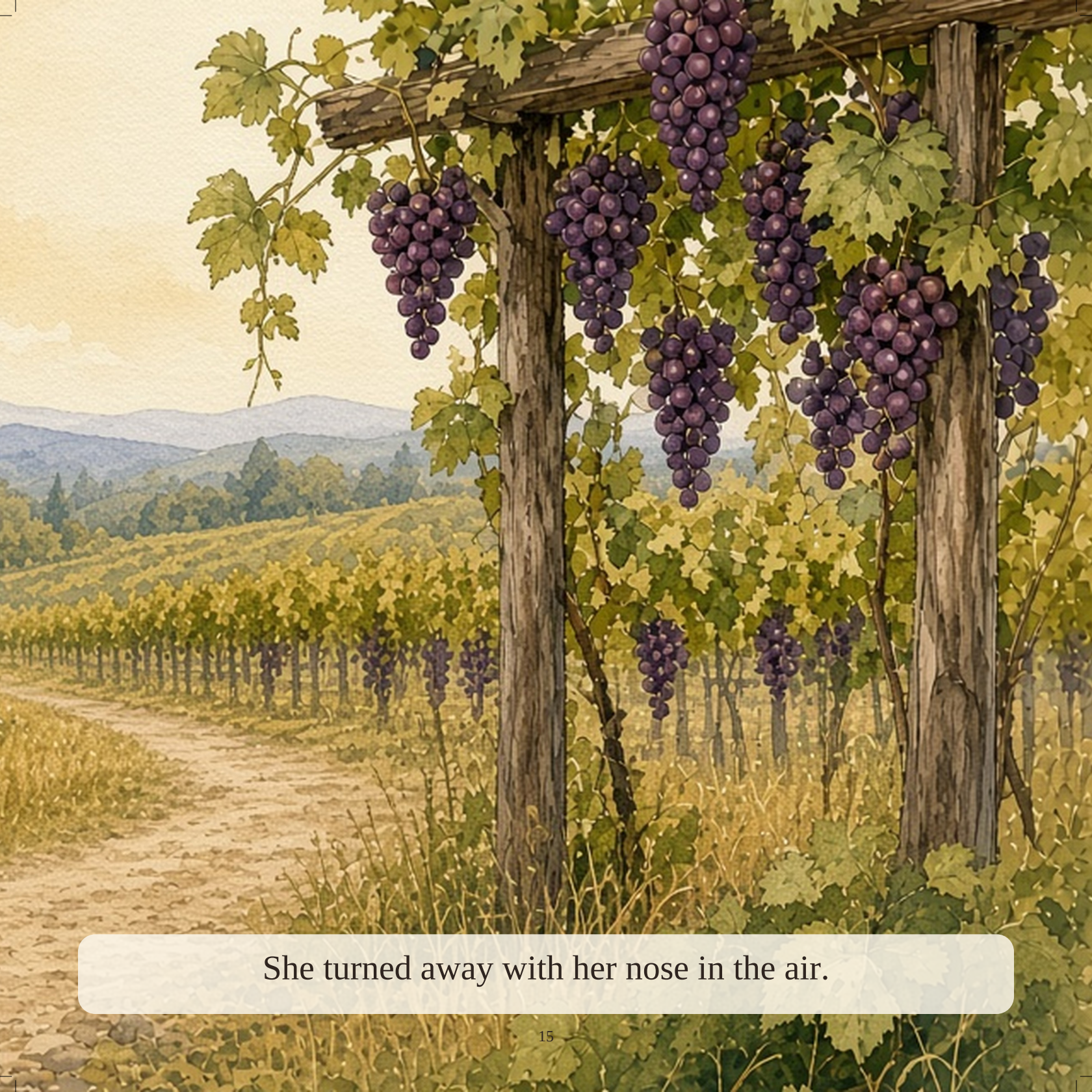
Fern backed up for one enormous jump.

Whoosh! Her nose brushed a leaf. Plop! She landed in the grass.

Fern sat down, puffing. She was tired, hungry, and disappointed.

Above her, the grapes glowed purple in the sun.

“They must be sour,” she grumbled. “I wouldn’t want them anyway.”



She turned away with her nose in the air.

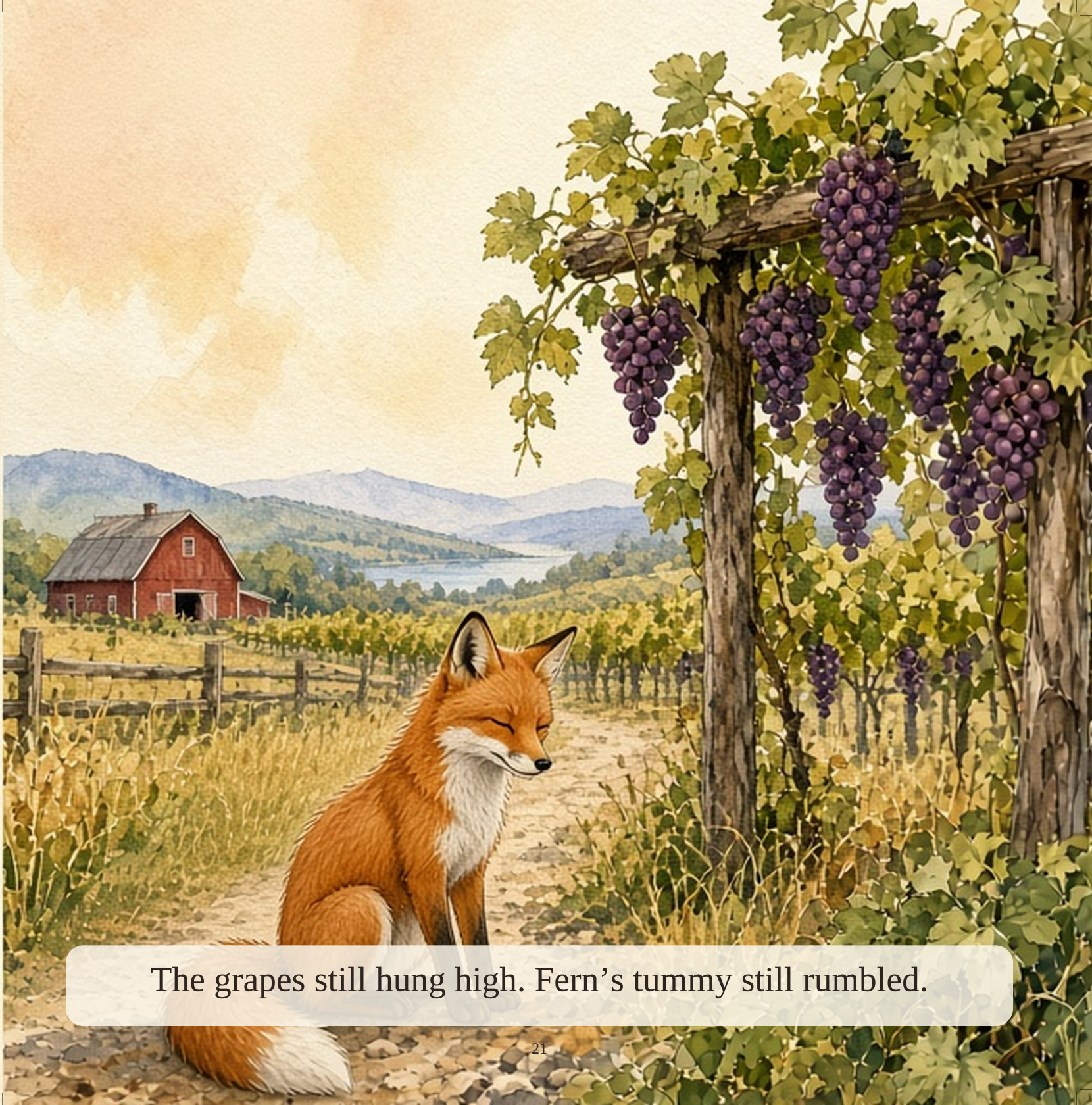
But after a few steps, Fern stopped.

She had not tasted even one grape. How could she know?

“I wanted them,” she admitted. “I’m upset because I can’t reach them.”

She let out a long, slow breath.

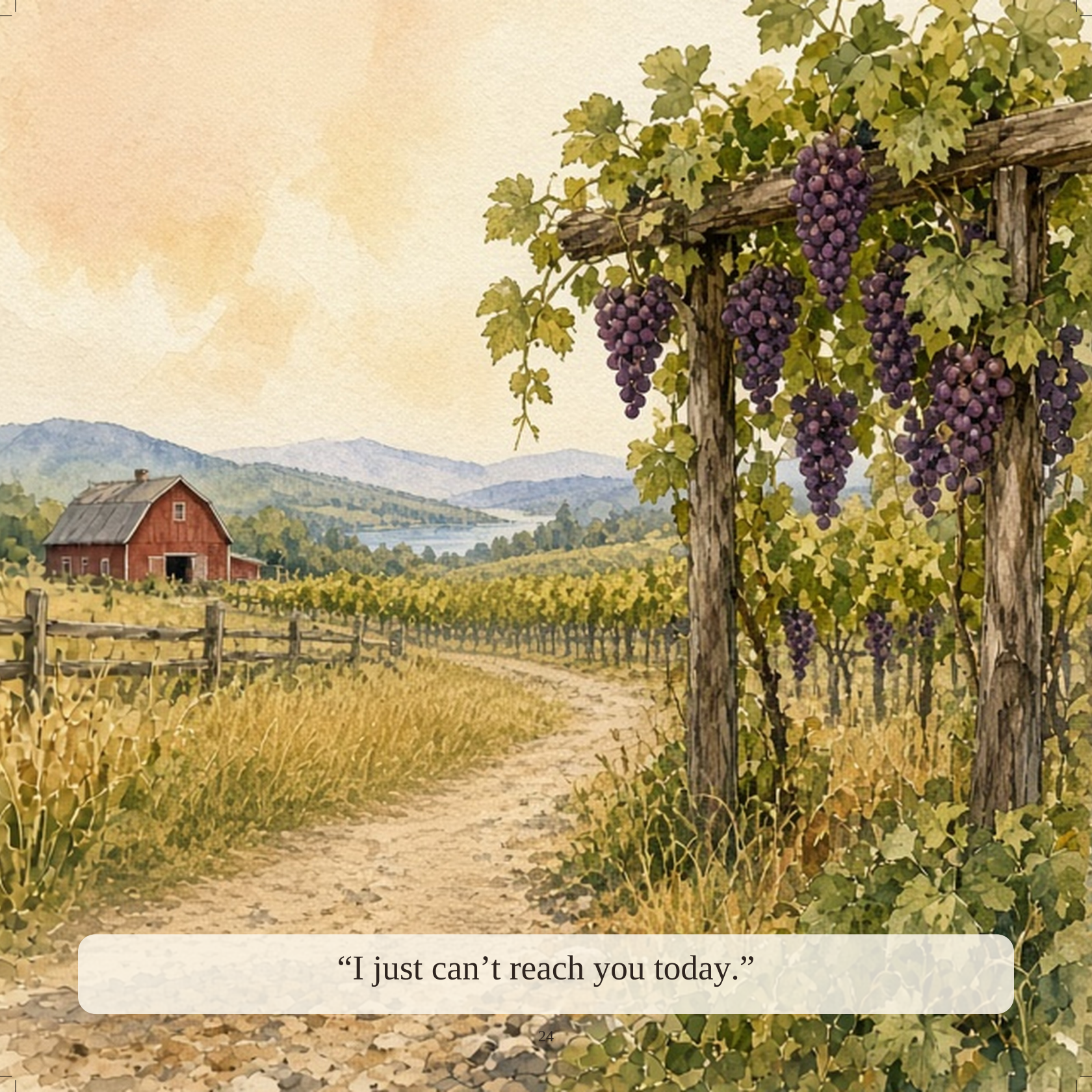
“God, please help me tell the truth and be thankful.”



The grapes still hung high. Fern’s tummy still rumbled.

She could be disappointed without saying something unkind.

“You may be perfectly good grapes,” she said.



“I just can’t reach you today.”

Fern padded to the shady creek and took a cool drink.

Then she rested her tired paws beneath a willow.

Soon she would look for supper. For now, she could leave the grapes in peace.

When we cannot have something, calling it bad does not make us truthful.

With God’s help, we can practice self-control and learn contentment.

But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. Against such things there is no law.

Galatians 5:22-23 (BSB)

I am not saying this out of need, for I have learned to be content regardless of my circumstances. I know how to live humbly, and I know how to abound. In any and every situation I have learned the secret of being filled and being hungry, of having plenty and having need.

Philippians 4:11-12 (BSB)

Source: "The Fox and the Grapes," The Fables of Phaedrus, Book IV, translated by Henry T. Riley and Christopher Smart (Project Gutenberg eBook #25512), archived at github.com/martyschoff/fables. This story is a NEW adaptation for young readers, not the words of Phaedrus, Riley, or Smart. Fern's pause, honest admission, prayer, and reconsideration are new material added in this adaptation. Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB). The BSB has been dedicated to the public domain.